

Dynamic Active Stabilisation mode is exclusively on the Sony ZV-E1 and even newer full-frame cameras like the A7C II do not feature this ...which is a shame.

Cinematic Vlog Modes

And then we get to the Cinematic Vlog Mode. I have been dreading writing about this part mostly because it does not make much sense to me, but the biggest question I have about it is, WHY? I mean I understand what it does and it may be useful to a lot of beginners who do not want to or know how to mess around with post-production but it still baffles me a bit. Oh wait, I haven't told you what it is yet, so let's get on that. Cinematic Vlog mode is a mode that makes your vlog look cinematic. Not good enough an explanation for ya? Fair enough. When enabled, this mode adds two black bars on the top and bottom of the frame. Basically, it adds a letterboxing effect. You cannot remove these black bars in post and there does not seem to be a way to not have them while still using Cinematic Mode. This is my major point of contention. Because using Cinematic Mode can be really fun for professionals and a useful training tool. It has various options in terms of the look you are going for and you can change it pretty easily to get an almost frame-by-frame comparison to figure out which look looks best. This mode almost Smartphone-ifies the experience, making the process of adding "looks" almost akin to adding filters on your phone.

Photo and Video Modes

Moving on to the sensor, picture quality and video quality now. What? A camera review where the most important part of the camera is up so late in the review? Blasphemous! Well, there are very good reasons for that! Reason number one is that the sensor is the same as the one you would see on the A7S III and FX3 which have been around for quite a while and everything that can be said about that sensor and its quality has been said. Secondly, we received a pretty battered and bruised ZV-E1 unit from Sony with a fingerprint on the



sensor and some mould on the lens. We promptly sent it back to Sony and received it again a couple of days later with a clean sensor and no visible signs of mould. However, when we pointed the camera at bright lights and compared the same with our production A7S III the picture on the ZV-E1 was not nearly as sharp as our A7S III. Which means the ZV-E1, although repaired was still not in prime condition. We suspect abuse by its previous users. Nevertheless, we were lucky enough to have a camera with the exact same sensor in the office (A7S III) and we are comfortable vouching for a non-abused version of the sensor in the ZV-E1.

Let's take a look at what you can actually do with all this. First up is photography. Although the cameras this 12 MP sensor has been put into are not necessarily photography-centric cameras such as the A7S III and FX3, it does a decent enough job and the image only falls apart when zooming in a lot. But for the target audience of this camera, the photography performance will more than suffice. If you wish to get higher resolutions you can go for Sony's Hybrid camera, the A7 IV with a 33 MP sensor or the majorly photography-centric A7R V with a whopping 61MP sensor. But what these cameras offer in terms of photography, the ZV-E1 claws back in video. This is the only camera in Sony's range that offers 4K video recording at 120p (via a

software update). It also shoots 4K at the usual 24p, 25p, 30p, 50p, 60p and 100p. Along with that, it shoots Full HD as well at all the above-mentioned frame rates and along with 240p.

A Professional's Envy

The Sony ZV-E1 is very difficult to quantify. It has some features that if implemented across the more professional cameras in Sony's range, would be highly appreciated. But then it lacks some of the features professionals cannot really do without. And on top of that, it is currently priced at Rs 2,14,990 (body only) which makes it quite out of reach for most vloggers and influencers. The only vlogger that would consider this camera would be one who generates enough revenue to justify this camera and is one who does not have a dedicated professional to do the shooting for them. Which makes this a very slim and niche subset of a subset.

I was very confused about its place in the market from the get go. But as I used it and understood more about everything it had to offer, I finally figured out. In my opinion, Sony might have unintentionally created the best camera that would be absolutely perfect as a Sony users' B-Cam. The camera that you can put on the gimbal and leave it there. And the cherry on the cake would be the amazing Dynamic Active Stabilisation which combined with the 5-axis stabilisation, a stabilised lens and a gimbal would result in the most eerily smooth video quality out there. So technically it is ideal for certain professional use cases. And of course for the hyper-successful, one-person show vlogger.

Sadly though when I asked some of our Indian professionals if they would consider the ZV-E1, the response was quite underwhelming. The problem I think is the marketing of the ZV-E1. In a bid to make it the ultimate "Vlogging" camera, Sony might have alienated a bigger market that would actually have the money to pay for it. But that's just a theory, and the end-of-quarter sales figures of the ZV-E1 would prove how correct or utterly wrong I am about this. **d**